

Teacher Guide

Heidi · Chapter 1: Going Up to the Alm-uncle · Grade 3

Lesson Overview

Tip: This lesson is designed to fit within a 60-minute instructional period. It may be split into two 30-minute sessions if needed.

Measurable Objectives

- Students will be able to identify who the main characters are and describe what each one is like, using details from the chapter. (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to explain why Deta brings Heidi to live with Alm-Uncle, using at least two details from the text. (RL.3.1)
- Students will be able to describe how the setting of the mountain changes the way characters feel and act during the chapter. (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to identify the meanings of the words *journey*, *explore*, *avoid*, *consider*, *responsible*, and *treasure* as they are used in the chapter. (RL.3.4)
- Students will be able to explain how Alm-Uncle feels when Heidi arrives, using details from what he says and does. (RL.3.1)
- Students will be able to write a sentence describing what Heidi is like, using at least one detail from the chapter to support their description. (W.3.1)

Standards

Standard	Description	Lesson Section(s)
Reading Literature		
RL.3.1	Ask and answer questions to demonstrate understanding of a text, referring explicitly to the text as the basis for the answers.	Think About the Story, Multiple Choice Questions, Evidence from the Story
RL.3.3	Describe characters in a story (e.g., their traits, motivations, or feelings) and explain how their actions contribute to the sequence of events.	Think About the Story, Reading Between the Lines, Character Chart
RL.3.4	Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in a text, distinguishing literal from nonliteral language.	Words to Know, Dig Deeper
RL.3.5	Refer to parts of stories, dramas, and poems when writing or speaking about a text, using terms such as chapter, scene, and stanza; describe how each successive part builds on earlier sections.	Bonus Challenge—Follow the Story, Thinking Deeper
RL.3.6	Distinguish their own point of view from that of the narrator or those of the characters.	Reading Between the Lines, Thinking Deeper
Writing		
W.3.1	Write opinion pieces on topics or texts, supporting a point of view with reasons.	Creative Response, Evidence from the Story
W.3.3	Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences.	Creative Response
W.3.4	With guidance and support from adults, produce writing in which the development and organization are appropriate to task and purpose.	Creative Response, Writing Rubric
W.3.5	With guidance and support from peers and adults, develop and strengthen writing as needed by planning, revising, and editing.	Writing Rubric
W.3.10	Write routinely over extended time frames (time for research, reflection, and revision) and shorter time frames (a single sitting or a day or two) for a range of discipline-specific tasks, purposes, and audiences.	Creative Response, Reflect on Your Drawing
Language		
L.3.4	Determine or clarify the meaning of unknown and multiple-meaning word and phrases based on grade 3 reading and content, choosing flexibly from a range of strategies.	Words to Know, Dig Deeper
L.3.5	Demonstrate understanding of figurative language, word relationships, and nuances in word meanings.	Words to Know, Reading Between the Lines
Speaking and Listening		
SL.3.1	Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions (one-on-one, in groups, and teacher-led) with diverse partners on grade 3 topics and texts, building on others' ideas and expressing their own clearly.	Get Ready to Read, Think About the Story, Dig Deeper
SL.3.3	Ask and answer questions about information from a speaker, offering appropriate elaboration and detail.	Think About the Story, Reading Between the Lines

Materials Needed

Materials needed

- Heidi, by Johanna Spyri (Classic Books for All edition), Chapter 1, for each student.
- Classic Books for All Heidi Student Workbook.
- Chart paper or whiteboard for class discussions.
- Sticky notes for exit tickets.
- Pencils, crayons/markers for graphic organizers.

Get Ready to Read

Quick-write prompt: "Think about a time you went somewhere new for the first time.

1. Display the prompt on the board or chart paper and read it aloud slowly so all students can follow along.
2. Give students 3–5 minutes to write their answer in their journals or on a sheet of paper. Remind them that there is no wrong answer — they are writing about their own experience.
3. Have students share their writing with a partner. Ask partners to listen and then tell each other one thing that was the same about their experiences.
4. Invite two or three volunteers to share with the whole class. Write a few key words or short phrases on the board as students share, such as "excited," "nervous," or "wanted to look around."
5. Connect students' ideas to the chapter by saying: "In Chapter 1, a five-year-old girl named Heidi arrives at a place she has never been before — her grandfather's hut high up in the mountains. As you read, notice how Heidi feels and what she wants to do when she gets there."

Connection tip: When students recall their own feelings about going somewhere new, they build background knowledge for understanding Heidi's excitement and curiosity as she climbs the mountain and arrives at Alm-Uncle's hut for the first time. This warm-up also helps students connect to the chapter's key — especially the word *explore* — before they encounter it on page 12.

Words to Know Mini-Lesson

Activities

Before students begin reading Chapter 1, take a few minutes to preview each vocabulary word so students know what to listen and look for. Tell students: "Today we are going to look at six words from the chapter. When you know what these words mean before you read, it is much easier to understand the story."

Walk through this worked example together as a class for the word *explore*:

- Word: *explore*
- Quote from chapter (page 12): "It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner."
- Context-clue strategy: Look at the words around *explore*. The sentence says Heidi thought being at her grandfather's hut was "an adventure" and that she was "eager" — which means she really wanted — to do something. When you put those clues together, you can figure out that *explore* means to go look around and find out what is there.
- Student-friendly definition: To *explore* means to go around a new place and look at everything to find out about it. Write the word, the quote, and the student-friendly definition on the board or chart paper so students can refer to them during reading.

Partner Practice

Pair students. Have each pair open their copy of Chapter 1 and find the remaining five vocabulary words: *avoid* (p. 4), *consider* (p. 3), *journey* (p. 7), *responsible* (p. 5), and *treasure* (p. 11). Partners should read the sentence that contains each word and then talk about what the word might mean using this sentence frame:

"I think [word] means ___ because the text says ___."

Remind students to look at the words before and after the vocabulary word for clues, just as the class did together with *explore*. Students may also begin filling in the "Definition using context clues" column in their workbook Words to Know chart as they discuss each word with their partner.

Quick Check

1. Call on 2–3 pairs to share their definitions. Ask each pair to read the sentence from the book aloud first, and then tell the class what they think the word means and why.
2. Confirm or correct each definition. Use the simple definitions below to guide your feedback:
 - *avoid* — to stay away from someone or something on purpose
 - *consider* — to think about doing something
 - *journey* — a trip from one place to another
 - *responsible* — doing what you are supposed to do and taking care of things the right way
 - *treasure* — something that is worth a lot or feels very special to you
3. Add each word to the classroom word wall after it is confirmed. If your word wall uses categories, these six words can be grouped under a heading such as "Chapter 1 Words."

Vocabulary tip: To support stronger readers, try a word-relationship activity: ask students to decide whether any of the six words are related in meaning. For example, *journey* and *explore* both involve going somewhere and moving around — how are they different? For students who need more support, provide a simple picture or gesture for each word (for example, mime looking around a room for *explore*, or cross your arms and step away for *avoid*) so that the meaning stays connected to something concrete as students read.

Guided Reading with Pause Points

Section 1: pages 1–4

Read from "In the cozy little town of Maienfeld, there's a pretty, green path" through "People avoid him because he looks and acts so scary."

Pause-point questions:

1. Where is Deta taking Heidi, and why? [question-type: comprehension]
2. Barbara says Deta "must be out of your mind to consider it." What does that tell you about how Barbara feels about the plan? [question-type: inference]
3. The text says people *avoid* Alm-Uncle. What details in the chapter help you understand why people stay away from him? [question-type: and inference]

Section 2: pages 5–7

Read from "Where has she gotten to now?" through "Barbara continued her journey up the mountain."

Pause-point questions:

1. What happened to Tobias and Adelheid, and how did those events affect Alm-Uncle? [question-type: comprehension]
2. Deta says she has "already done a lot for Heidi." Do you think Deta is making a good choice by leaving Heidi with Alm-Uncle? Use details from the chapter to explain your thinking. [question-type: evaluation]

Section 3: pages 8–11

Read from "Every day, Peter would collect the goats from his village" through "Peter didn't often get such a treasure."

Pause-point questions:

1. Why does Heidi take off her heavy clothes and shoes while climbing the mountain? [question-type: comprehension]
2. The text says the five-penny coin was a *treasure* to Peter. What does that tell you about what Peter's life is like? [question-type: and inference]
3. How are Heidi and Peter similar in the way they act on the mountain path? [question-type: inference]

Section 4: pages 11–13

Read from "After almost an hour, they reached Heidi's grandfather's hut" through "No one helped me. I already had my mother to care for."

Pause-point questions:

1. What does Heidi do and say when she first sees Alm-Uncle at his hut? [question-type: comprehension]
2. Alm-Uncle worries that Heidi will start "missing you and crying." What does that worry tell you about how he feels about taking care of a small child? [question-type: inference]
3. The text says Heidi "was eager to explore every corner." How does the way Heidi acts at the hut compare to how Alm-Uncle acts? [question-type: analysis]

Read-aloud tip: When you reach page 12, slow down and read Alm-Uncle's gruff dialogue in a low, rumbling voice. Then read Heidi's cheerful "Hello, Grandfather!" in a bright, light voice. The contrast between the two voices helps students notice right away that these two characters are very different from each other — and sets up a great discussion about how Alm-Uncle's face "softens into a smile" even though his words sound unfriendly.

Think About the Story — Answers + Inferential Thinking

Q: What is the name of the little girl being taken up the mountain?

A: The little girl's name is Heidi (p. 3).

Q: What does Heidi say when Deta asks if she is tired?

A: Heidi says she is not tired, but hot (p. 3).

Q: What clothes does Heidi take off while climbing the mountain with Peter and the goats?

A: Heidi takes off her shoes, socks, her heavy shawl, and two dresses so that she is wearing only a light undershirt (p. 8–9).

Q: Where is Deta going for her new job?

A: Deta is going to a beautiful house in Frankfurt (p. 3).

Q: What does Deta give Peter so he will go back down the hill to fetch Heidi's clothes?

A: Deta gives Peter a five-penny coin (p. 9).

Q: Where is Grandfather sitting when Heidi and Deta arrive at the hut?

A: Grandfather is sitting on a bench by the side of his hut, looking out over the valley (p. 11).

Inferential Thinking — deeper follow-ups

1. The text says Grandfather's face "softened into a smile" when he first heard Heidi's voice, even though his words sounded gruff and unwelcoming. What does that tell you about how he really feels when Heidi arrives? Why do you think he acts grumpy if he is also smiling inside?
2. Deta says she has "already done a lot for Heidi" and that it is now Grandfather's turn to take care of her. Do you think Deta is being fair to Heidi, or is she just thinking about herself? Use at least one detail from the chapter to explain your thinking.
3. Heidi takes off her heavy clothes without asking anyone and then says simply, "I didn't need them." What does this tell you about what kind of person Heidi is? How is the way Heidi acts on the mountain different from the way most adults in the chapter act?

Differentiated Supports

Struggling Readers

Before reading:

- Preview the six words together. For each word, say the word, show a simple gesture or action (for example, step away and cross your arms for *avoid*; pretend to look around a new room for *explore*), and say the simple definition in one short sentence. Ask students to repeat the gesture and the definition after you.
- Show students a simple hand-drawn map or diagram on the board: a village at the bottom, a winding path going up, and a small hut at the top. Point to each spot and say, "Deta and Heidi start here. They walk up this path. They end up here at Grandfather's hut." This picture helps students track the journey before they read a single word.

During reading:

- Read pages 1–4 aloud to the class. Pause after each paragraph and ask one simple question students can answer by pointing to a sentence, such as: "Where is Deta taking Heidi?" or "What does Barbara think about the plan?" Let students put their finger on the sentence that gives the answer.
- When the class reaches page 8, where Heidi takes off her heavy clothes, stop and act it out briefly. Mime pulling off a heavy coat, shawl, and shoes, then say "Ahh, much better!" This short movement break helps struggling readers hold on to what Heidi is doing and why she feels so much happier climbing with Peter after that.

After reading:

- Give students a simple three-box sequence strip. In box one they draw or write what happens at the village. In box two they draw or write what happens on the mountain path with Peter. In box three they draw or write what happens when Heidi arrives at Grandfather's hut. This helps students retell the chapter in order without having to hold the whole story in their head at once.
- Use a sentence frame to help students answer the first inferential thinking question about Grandfather's face: "Even though Grandfather sounds gruff, his face _____ when Heidi arrives. This tells me he really feels _____." Students can look back at page 11 to find the words they need.

English Language Learners

Before reading:

- Pre-teach the four key character names and relationships before reading begins: Heidi (the little girl), Deta (her aunt), Alm-Uncle (her grandfather), and Peter (the goat herder boy). Write each name on the board next to a one-phrase description. Say each name aloud and have students repeat it so the names feel familiar when they appear in the text.
- For each word, pair the student-friendly definition from the Words to Know Mini-Lesson with a picture or simple example from everyday life. For instance, pair *journey* with a picture of a path or road, and *treasure* with a picture of something small but precious. Students can keep a personal word card for each word with the definition written in both English and, if possible, their home language.

During reading:

- When the text uses descriptive phrases about the mountain setting on pages 1 and 11 — such as "the sweet scent of herbs," "bare, steep cliffs," and "the whole valley" — pause and describe each phrase in plain words. For example: "steep cliffs means rocks that go almost straight up and down, like a wall." These descriptions help students build a picture of the setting so they can follow the characters' actions in context.
- At each pause point in Section 3 (pages 8–11), offer a sentence frame for the partner discussion. For example: "Heidi took off her clothes because she felt _____. I know this because the text says _____." Frames lower the language barrier so students can show their thinking even when they are still building English fluency.

After reading:

- Ask students to choose two words from the chapter — such as *journey* and *explore* — and draw a two-panel picture: one panel showing the word's meaning, and one panel showing a moment from Chapter 1 where that word fits. Students label each panel with the word. This lets them demonstrate comprehension through drawing and single words before moving to full sentences.
- For the inferential thinking question about whether Deta is being fair to Heidi, provide this sentence frame: "I think Deta is / is not being fair because the text says _____ on page _____. " Read the question aloud twice before students respond, and allow partner talk before writing.

Advanced Students**Before reading:**

- Ask advanced students to look at the six words and group them before reading. Challenge them to think: which words describe how a person acts or thinks (*avoid*, *consider*, *responsible*), and which words describe experiences or things (*journey*, *explore*, *treasure*)? Ask them to be ready to explain their grouping after the mini-lesson.
- Before reading Chapter 1, pose this thinking question for students to hold in their minds as they read: "Who in this chapter has the hardest job — Deta, Alm-Uncle, or Peter — and why?" Tell them to gather evidence from the chapter text to support their answer, which they will share after reading.

During reading:

- At the end of Section 2 (pages 5–7), ask advanced students to consider two points of view at the same time: Deta says she has "already done a lot for Heidi" and that it is Grandfather's turn. Barbara thinks leaving Heidi is a terrible idea. Ask students to write one sentence explaining each character's point of view, and one sentence saying which point of view they agree with and why.
- When the class pauses at the end of Section 4 (pages 11–13) to discuss how Grandfather's face "softened into a smile," ask advanced students to go further: Why might Grandfather act gruff with words but show kindness in his expression? Ask them to connect this to what they learned about Grandfather's past on pages 5–7, using the words *responsible* and *avoid* in their explanation if possible.

After reading:

- Ask advanced students to write a short paragraph — at least four sentences — from Alm-Uncle's point of view on the day Heidi arrives. They should use at least two details from the chapter and at least one word from the chapter (*consider*, *responsible*, *treasure*, or another word from the list). Remind them to think about what Grandfather says, what his face does, and what the text tells us about his past.
- Challenge advanced students to answer the third inferential thinking question in writing: "Heidi takes off her heavy clothes without asking anyone and says simply, 'I didn't need them.' How is the way Heidi acts on the mountain different from the way most adults in the chapter act?" Students should name at least two adults from Chapter 1 and use specific details from the text to support their comparison.

Common Student Questions

1. **Q:** Why does Deta leave Heidi with the old man if he is so scary?

A: Deta has been offered a job in Frankfurt and cannot bring Heidi with her. She feels it is now Alm-Uncle's turn to take care of Heidi since he is Heidi's grandfather. (p. 3, 7)

2. **Q:** Why do people call him "Alm-Uncle" if he is not really their uncle?

A: The villagers started calling him "Uncle" as a nickname a long time ago, and when he moved to the Alm — the name for his spot on the mountain — everyone put the two names together and called him "Alm-Uncle." (p. 5)

3. **Q:** Why does Heidi take off all her clothes on the mountain path?

A: Heidi is wearing many heavy layers because Deta dressed her in her Sunday clothes over her everyday clothes, and the extra weight makes her very hot. When she sees how freely Peter and the goats move, she takes the extra clothes off so she can climb more easily. (p. 8–9)

4. **Q:** Why does Peter run down the hill to get Heidi's clothes when he said he was already late?

A: Deta offers Peter a five-penny coin to go back for the clothes. The coin is a big deal to Peter because he rarely gets money of his own, so he jumps at the chance and hurries down right away. (p. 9, 11)

5. **Q:** Does Grandfather want Heidi to stay with him?

A: Grandfather sounds grumpy and worried when Deta brings Heidi — he asks what he is supposed to do if Heidi cries and misses her family. Even so, the text says his face "softened into a smile" when he first heard Heidi's voice, which shows he may care more than he lets on. (p. 11–12)

6. **Q:** What happened to Heidi's mom and dad?

A: Heidi's father was Tobias, Alm-Uncle's son. Tobias died in an accident while building a house. Heidi's mother, Adelheid, became so sad that she grew ill and also passed away not long after. (p. 7)

7. **Q:** Who is Peter, and why is he on the mountain?

A: Peter is an eleven-year-old boy who works as a goat herder. Every day he collects the goats from the village, leads them up the mountain to eat grass, and brings them back down in the evening. (p. 7–8)

8. **Q:** Why does Deta say she has "already done a lot for Heidi"?

A: After Heidi's mother died, Deta and her own mother took baby Heidi in and cared for her for four years. Deta feels she has done her share and that it is now Alm-Uncle's responsibility to help raise Heidi. (p. 7, 12)

Creative Response

Common errors

No Specific Details From The Chapter

Some students will write in general terms about Heidi going to the mountain without naming anything specific that happened, such as taking off her heavy clothes on the path or calling out "Good evening, Grandfather!" when she arrived at the hut. A response like "Heidi went up the mountain and met her grandfather" does not show the student used the chapter text.

Breaking Character

Some students will slip out of Heidi's point of view and start writing as themselves, saying things like "I think Heidi was happy" instead of writing as Heidi and describing what she sees, feels, and does from inside the story. The response should stay in Heidi's voice and experience from start to finish.

Retelling The Whole Chapter Instead of Focusing on Heidi's Experience

Some students will try to summarize everything that happens in Chapter 1, including what Deta says to Barbara, the story of Tobias and Adelheid, and why Peter ran back down the hill for the clothes. The prompt asks students to focus on what Heidi herself notices and feels, not to retell every event in the chapter.

No Evidence From the Text

Some students will write about how Heidi feels using only their own imagination, without connecting their ideas to anything in the chapter. For example, a student might write that Heidi was scared of Grandfather without pointing to anything Heidi says or does in the text, such as the way she walks right up to him and holds out her hand on page 12.

Modern Language That Doesn't Fit The Story.

Some students will use words and phrases that sound like everyday conversation today rather than matching the tone of the story, writing things like "This place is so cool" or "Grandfather was kind of weird." The writing should sound like it belongs in the world of the story, using simple but fitting language rather than current slang or casual modern expressions.

Exit Ticket

Prompt

At the end of Chapter 1, Heidi arrives at Grandfather's hut and is "eager to explore every corner." Think about what Heidi says and does when she meets Grandfather. What do her words and actions tell you about the kind of person she is? Write 2–4 sentences and use at least one detail from the chapter.

Success Criteria

- The student makes a clear statement about what Heidi is like as a person.
- The student uses at least one detail from the chapter — such as what Heidi says, does, or how she acts when she meets Grandfather — to support their statement.
- The response is written in 2–4 complete sentences.

Example Responses

1. Heidi is brave and friendly. When she gets to Grandfather's hut, she walks right up to the old man and calls out, "Good evening, Grandfather!" She does not seem scared of him at all, even though the whole village thinks he is scary.
2. Heidi is curious and happy. She bounces around looking at everything and is eager to explore the hut and the mountain. This shows she is excited about new places instead of being afraid of them.